

Chapter 3: Dwarves and Duergar

To impartial observers, the tale of the ancient war between dwarves and duergar is at its heart a tragedy, the story of a people turned against each other by bitterness and resentment. Once the dwarves were unified in their worship of Moradin, the deity who crafted the first dwarves from metal and fire. Today, the race is splintered into those who still embrace him as their father and creator—and those who have sworn to topple him from his divine throne.

While the dwarves loyal to Moradin take joy in the art of crafting and form strong family bonds, the duergar are joyless, hateful creatures who create their works out of an urge to build and acquire. They come closest to feeling true joy when they raid dwarven strongholds to satisfy their lust for blood and treasure.

The Deep Roots of War

Take this message to your doddering fool of a *god. His turn is coming, Laduguer willing.*

—Duergar assassin Vozala Spikefist, before slaying the dwarf king Umbrag Hammerthorn

The conflict began in ages past, when the world was new. Almost all the dwarves were more than content to make their homes inside the mountains and hills that were filled with ore and other valuables, not digging too far beneath the surface. The dwarves of clan Duergar, however, became obsessed with delving deep into the Underdark. The clan's miners continually insisted that a great trove of gold and iron lay just beyond where the clan had explored. The next strike of a pick, they said, could reveal wealth beyond imagining.

This obsession took root and spread throughout the clan. Soon, all other activity in the community ceased; the forges grew cold, and the temples to Moradin stood empty. Every dwarf old enough to hold a pick or shovel worked the mines.

The dwarves relentlessly dug, hacked, and tunneled. The weakest among them fell dead from exhaustion, the rest pausing only long enough to push the corpses aside so they could continue the digging.

Only the hardiest and most iron-willed individuals of the clan survived this brutal campaign. When their delving finally broke through into a cavern, the dwarves found the cause of their obsession. A great elder brain and its mind flayers waited there, ready to take the next step in the subjugation of clan Duergar. The monsters had sent out a psychic lure that played on the dwarves' greed, and the never-ending work schedule that was the product of their obsession weeded out all but the best specimens for their slave pens. The illithids had no trouble overwhelming the remaining dwarves with their psionic power and soon put them to work.



The dwarves proved to be able slaves, but the elder brain saw within them another kind of usefulness. The dwarves' innate ability to resist the effects of harmful substances such as poison made them suitable subjects for a variety of grisly experiments. Generations of psychic surgery and physical alterations mutated the captives into creatures that had special powers of their own.

In time, a leader arose among the enslaved dwarves. Named Laduguer, he struck a deal with Asmodeus, pledging the assistance of clan Duergar against Lolth's ambitions in the Underdark. With the help of the Lord of the Nine, the dwarves overthrew their illithid masters in a great uprising. At last, Laduguer could bring his clan upward to rejoin the world they had left behind.

Triumph Turned Sour

When Laduguer and his people returned to the dwarves of the upper world, they were shocked by the hostility they faced. As Laduguer quickly learned, the priests of Moradin had long ago labeled the lost clan as heretics, spoken of now only as an object lesson concerning the fate of dwarves who stray from Moradin's teachings.

When Laduguer protested this treatment, the priests insisted that Moradin had sent omens and warnings to the lost dwarves, but they went unheeded. Envoys from the other clans had found clan Duergar's stronghold abandoned, with no evidence of invasion, plague, or other calamity. Even worse, the temples of Moradin had been left untended. Only laziness, greed, and contempt for the All-Father could account for the clan's fate.

Laduguer, in response, tried to explain that his people had been lured into a trap by the mind flayers, but his assertions fell on deaf ears. Thus, with no other apparent choice, the lost clan fled back to the Underdark. Laduguer focused his fury on Moradin. The dwarves' supposed father had turned a blind eye as they fell into the mind flayers' trap, then sat idle as the clan suffered unspeakable abuses. Laduguer and his followers swore that they wouldn't rest until the father of the dwarves lay dead and Laduguer sat upon his throne.

Of course, by declaring his intent to destroy Moradin, Laduguer created a state of war between the duergar and the other dwarves in the world. Since that time, the duergar have not eased up on their hostility, and the dwarves have not relaxed their vigilance.

Conflict without End

Few others aside from the dwarves and the duergar understand or appreciate the true scope and intensity of the battles between these two races. Viewed on a grand scale, the conflict is a great war of attrition—the combatants don't often gain or lose territory as the result of battle. But on a personal scale, combat is brutal, with no quarter given or expected.

The duergar fight a persistent guerrilla war of sudden raids and brutal attacks against isolated groups of dwarves. Duergar often begin an attack by burrowing into a dwarf settlement from below, then bursting out in a vicious assault that leaves few survivors. If robbery rather than murder is the goal, a duergar war party

might surreptitiously dig for weeks to penetrate a dwarf treasure vault, hoping to seize a clan's riches from beneath its noses.

For their part, the dwarves keep safety and defense uppermost in their priorities, realizing that there is little to be gained from trying to mount a large-scale assault against the duergar. They actively protect their strongholds, keeping careful watch for signs of tunneling, and—dwarven pride being what it is—send bands of warriors out from time to time to deal reprisals to duergar camps and fortresses. In addition to these rare offensive thrusts, dwarves sometimes send small squads of explorers or scouts into the Underdark to learn about duergar activity or to recover stolen treasures if they can do so without attracting too much attention.

This eternal enmity between duergar and dwarves doesn't consume either side; both have other concerns and needs that take much of their time and attention, At the same time, the never-ending state of war is never out of mind—every dwarf knows that a chance encounter with a duergar could be fatal, and every duergar would like nothing better than to have such an opportunity.

Dwarves

The dwarf god Moradin forged the first dwarves in his great workshop, causing them to spring to life from inert metal when he cooled the heated castings with his breath. Since then, the dwarves have revered Moradin and sought to follow in his footsteps. Through constant, steady work, they strive to emulate the perfect example set by the originator of the arts and skills the dwarves pursue.

To the dwarves, Moradin is the Creator. With his impeccable skills, he crafted the first dwarves and imbued them with a sense of relentless purpose, driven to apply their own crafting skills to the raw materials around them and thereby unlock the beauty that hides within.

Moradin is also worshiped as the All-Father, in acknowledgment of his role as the progenitor of the dwarven race. In this aspect as well, he is credited not only for the birth of the dwarves but for fostering in them a deep appreciation for clan and family. He demonstrates how dwarf parents should raise their children, instilling in them the urge to further not only themselves but to contribute to the success of the larger group. Just as Moradin looks out for all dwarves, all dwarves in a clan look out for one another.

The Path to Perfection

Every fall of the hammer on the anvil, every fire *stoked in the forge, is a step on a journey set before me by Moradin himself. It isn't work. It is a challenge to achieve greatness.*

—Balifra Eversharp

Dwarves have a strong sense of their progress, and each day that goes by must bring them closer to the standard set by Moradin. Acutely aware of their mortality, they see the many centuries afforded to them as too short a time to risk wasting even a single day in indolence.

Dwarves pursue perfection. This chase is foolish. There is no one pure truth of anything.

Moradin crafted the dwarves' sturdy bodies, giving them the strength to work for long periods of time. Rather than imparting his skills to them, he fueled their spirits with a burning desire to follow his example. His gifts of durability and purpose gave the dwarves all they needed to devote their lives to steady work, refining their skills and improving their inner selves while they transform rock and ore into wondrous creations.

Lifetimes of Glorious Labor

Dwarf artisans regard the fruits of their labors with the same love that members of other races reserve for their children. A dwarf's works are built to last for centuries, to carry a legacy into the world long after the dwarf is gone. Each item a dwarf crafts is a milepost on the path to perfection, a step taken toward mastering a technique. All of one's works taken together are the physical representation of a dwarf's accomplishments. A dwarf who has lived a good, fruitful life leaves behind a rich legacy of wondrous goods—gleaming metal goblets, gem-encrusted stone sculptures, tapestries made of ores and minerals, finely honed weapons, or the end result of any other endeavor that enriches the crafter while it pays homage to the Creator.

Dwarves guard their personal creations with the vigilance and ferocity of a dragon protecting a treasure hoard. Such protectiveness isn't often called for in the company of friends and family—but just as a parent doesn't leave a child unattended, a dwarf doesn't craft an item and then knowingly leave it vulnerable to being stolen (or worse). A dwarf who loses an item to thievery pursues the item's recovery or seeks vengeance against the thieves with the same fury that parents direct against those who kidnapped their child.

At the other extreme, a dwarf's gift of a personal item to someone else is a deep expression of commitment, love, and trust. The beneficiary of the gift is expected to provide the item with the same careful stewardship exhibited by its creator—never letting it fall into an enemy's hands and sparing no effort to recover it if is stolen.

Minds as Rigid as Stone

Although the dwarves' obsessive pursuit of perfection in the arts of crafting leads them to produce great works, it comes at a price. Dwarves value stability, repetition, and tradition above all else. Chaos and change cause distractions from the task at hand. Dwarves crave predictability, routine, and safety. A mind not fully focused can't give a task its proper attention.

This rigidity in outlook, though a fundamental part of the dwarven psyche, can sometimes be a disadvantage. Dwarves don't change their minds easily, and once set on a course rarely alter their strategy. Their commitment to following a plan serves them well when they build a stone bridge designed to last for centuries, but the same inflexibility can bring problems when applied to the unpredictable dangers of the world. A clan might

continue to depend on the same plan for defending its stronghold that has been used for centuries, without considering the possibility that its enemies have discovered how to overcome those defenses.

The dwarves' way of thinking leads to difficulties in their relationships with humans and elves. From their long-lived perspective, dwarves can't understand the speed with which human communities and civilizations rise and fall. If a trade delegation from a dwarven stronghold were to visit a human town once every twenty or thirty years—not a long time to a dwarf—the community's leaders would likely be different every time, and for the dwarves the experience would be akin to making first contact all over again. Establishing trade with this "new" human outpost would require forming new relationships, a process that could take weeks or months.

The elves' chaotic nature and love of the wilderness baffle the dwarves, who think of them as somewhat mad. Dwarves typically find elves too flighty to ever fully trust them, believing that creatures that thrive on change and chaos can't possibly be reliable allies.

In particular situations, of course, the benefits of cooperating with humans or elves can override the dwarves' concern about the shortcomings of those races. When dwarves, humans, and elves have a common enemy, they all find a way to work together for the common good.

All for One: The Clan

SO THE BARMAN ISN'T A RELATIVE, AND YOU DON'T EVEN *know the names of any of the folk here? How can you possibly sleep peacefully in this inn, surrounded by strangers? We'll be lucky to see the morning.*

—Tordek

The clan is the basic unit of dwarven society, an extended family that dwells together. Everything a dwarf does in life is devoted to improving or helping the clan, bringing security and stability to its members and greater glory to the group.

The most important clan members to any dwarf are the members of one's immediate family, because the instinctive connection between parent and child is stronger than the attachment between unrelated clan members. Nevertheless, the distinction is so slim as to be unnoticeable to outsiders—dwarves will endure hardship or lay down their lives for any of their clan mates, whether related to them by blood or by the devotion that holds the clan together.

The Greatest Legacy

The life of a dwarf is all about doing good work and leaving behind a fitting legacy that continues to bolster the clan even after its creator has passed on—a legacy counted not only in objects, but also in dwarven souls. Dwarves who become parents rightfully think of their children as the greatest legacy they can leave the clan, and they raise them with the same care and attention to detail that they give to the items they create. A dwarf's direct descendants—beloved sons, daughters, and grandchildren—are often the ones who inherit the inanimate works their ancestor leaves behind.

Dwarves are creatures of stone, and like stone they change only in response to extremes. The dwarves of the many worlds share much in common, but never allow those similarities to blind you to their unique traits.

Marriage is a sacred rite among the dwarves, taken very seriously because it requires two children to move away from their homes to start a new family in the clan. The affected families feel a sense of loss that is healed only when a new dwarf child enters the world—an event that calls for great celebration.

Few dwarves develop romantic feelings for their spouses, at least not in the way that other races do. They view their spouses as collaborators and co-creators, their elders as respected experts to be obeyed, and their children as their most treasured creations. The emotion that underlies all those feelings might not be love, as others would term it, but it is just as intense.

Roles in the Clan

Every clan calls upon its members to fill three principal roles, each of which contributes to the group's welfare.

First, many dwarves support the clan by working at an occupation that sustains the community—brewing ale, tending crops, and preparing food, for instance. Not everyone can be a master artisan or a vigilant warrior; the clan needs a wide range of labor and talents to meet all the needs of the group.

Filling the second role are an equally large number of dwarves whose occupations involve the crafting of items and other forms of creation—smelting, smithing, gem-cutting, sculpture, and similar tasks. These artisans are responsible for making the items that help the clan protect its stronghold.

The third function is performed by those who navigate the space between the clan and the chaotic creatures of the outside world. These dwarves are merchants, warriors, and envoys, tasked with representing the dwarves in dealings with other races and with providing a buffer between the clan and the potential threats of creatures and communities in the vicinity of the stronghold.

A dwarf assigned to a role takes years to master it. A weaponsmith starts work in the forge, providing manual labor to haul ore from the mines and learning how to repair tools. The dwarf might then work in the mines, pushing carts and learning to pick out the best ore samples from a lode. Slowly but surely, a dwarf masters every aspect of a task or an occupation from start to finish.

Leadership and Government

A clan is led by a king or a queen who sits at the head of a noble family. Dwarf nobles are members of families that claim direct ancestry to the first dwarves crafted by Moradin. To the dwarves, leadership is a craft like any other activity, calling for careful practice and constant



attention to detail in order to yield the best, most satisfying results.

Young nobles apprentice for a time with masters of every profession in the clan. This period of work and education has two important results. First, the apprenticeships expose a young noble to each part of the clan's operation and create personal ties between the apprentice and every group in the clan's society. By the time a noble takes on a leadership role, the noble has a clear overview of all the clan's interrelationships and has formed friendships with people from every spot on the spectrum of roles within the clan.

More important, a young noble's conduct while pursuing a variety of tasks gives the elder nobles a chance to assess the youth's character. Ideally, a noble who ascends to the leadership of a clan demonstrates an even temperament and an affinity for the clan's key functions. A noble who particularly enjoys fighting might become a minister of war or a general, while one who loves smithing might become an overseer of the crafters' work.

One for All: The Stronghold

I LIVE HERE AMONG MY FOLK, AND I SWEAR THAT IF NEED *be I will die here atop a mountain of my enemies' corpses.*

—King Ulaar Strongheart

Every dwarf clan maintains a stronghold, typically a series of chambers dug out beneath a mountain or inside a hill. The stronghold is a haven from the chaos of the outside world, allowing the dwarves to toil in peace. The first concern of any stronghold is defense, but older and prosperous strongholds can grow to become wondrous underground cities filled with generations of exquisite dwarven artisanship.

Regardless of a clan's size and status, its stronghold is a stony personification of the clan itself—what's good for the clan is good for the stronghold, and vice versa. If a stronghold fails from within, or falls victim to outside forces, such an event is often the clan's death knell.

A Living Monument

The masons and stone carvers in a clan consider the stronghold to be their greatest work. In a typical stronghold, stone bridges arc over chasms, their surfaces embellished with fine carvings and intricate patterns. The great stone doors leading outside can withstand a battering ram when secured, but glide open at the touch of a child when they are unlocked. While some other races erect statues or build special structures to honor their heroes or commemorate momentous events, the dwarves live and work within their greatest memorial.

A clan's stronghold holds the record of its history and accomplishments. A work that an outsider regards as "merely" intricate stone carving might actually be a carefully composed recounting of deeds, events, and important persons. Dwarves combine their runes into patterns, present pictorial histories in seemingly unconnected murals and images, and otherwise leave their clan's legacy of accomplishments hiding in plain sight. The story of the clan is meant to be appreciated by clan members and fellow dwarves, not the few outsiders who might be allowed inside the stronghold.



Island of Stability

A well-built stronghold is an easily managed, tranquil environment where dwarves focus on rearing their families and pursuing their craft. Since the beginnings of their existence, dwarves have carved out their strongholds underground for a variety of reasons. Their unmatched prowess in mining and stonework makes them ideal candidates to use the subterranean realm for living quarters—and considering their outlook on the rest of the world, the dwarves wouldn't have it any other way.

The stronghold's remoteness isolates the dwarves from the vagaries of politics and other forms of turmoil in the surface world. Underground, they don't have to contend with the changing of the seasons, or even daily variations in the weather, so that one day inside a stronghold is much like any other day. The activities of the clan are governed by a firm schedule that provides every member with daily time for work, family, and personal enrichment. The forges are never allowed to go cold, and the mines around the stronghold are worked every hour of every day.

Beautiful on the Inside

Dwarves are acutely aware that their reputation as skilled miners and crafters of beautiful works of art makes any stronghold a prime target for thieves and raiders. For that reason, the entrance to a stronghold doesn't broadcast its presence by being a stellar example of dwarven stonework. The outer precincts of a clan's home are plain and functional, decorated minimally or not at all, to give visitors and those passing nearby no reason to suspect what lies in the deeper chambers. From what they see, a dwarven stronghold is well built but austere.

The greatest treasures crafted by a clan are sequestered in the innermost chambers of the stronghold, behind secret doors in areas that are open to clan members but forbidden to all outsiders. Even dwarves from other clans are granted access to such a place only after earning the trust of their hosts.

These inner precincts hold the stuff of a thief's wildest dreams. In one chamber, gold foil lines the ceiling of an immense hall, carefully worked with diamonds that mimic the stars at night. In another, jewels are used to form wondrous murals that tell of the clan's greatest deeds. A clan's feasting hall might be stocked with utensils and place settings made of silver and gold.

Defense Comes First

Every dwarf knows instinctively that clan and stronghold are inextricably tied together—if one comes undone, the other fails as well. As such, defending the stronghold is a concern that the dwarves address even in the earliest stages of construction. They plan and then build with the goals of safety and security uppermost in mind. And the only way that a home can be truly safe and secure is if it is protected against intruders.

Dwarves use a variety of approaches and devices in setting their defenses. The strongholds of many clans are honeycombed with secret passages designed to enable the dwarves to ambush and flank enemies. Dwarves also make liberal use of secret doors fashioned

by dwarf artisans, slabs of stone that fit so precisely in their openings that no one but a dwarf knows how to locate and open one.

Unlike some other races that guard their territory by creating features that actively deter invaders, dwarves rarely use arrow traps, pit traps, and other such measures that could cause harm to clan members. They see little sense in risking injury if a trap of that sort malfunctioned or was accidentally triggered by a dwarf. A defensive measure isn't doing its job if it ends up hurting those it was meant to protect.

Dwarves of the Multiverse

Like any race, dwarves display a wide array of skin tones, hair colors, and other physical traits. Adding to this diversity, they have a variety of cultural identities from world to world across the multiverse.

Dwarves of Greyhawk

The hill dwarves and mountain dwarves of war-wracked Oerth have endured many centuries of turbulence. Their outlook on the world is shaped largely by how they perceive outsiders and how much of a threat those outsiders might pose.

Hill Dwarves. Most of the dwarves on Oerth are hill dwarves. Compared to the mountain dwarves, they have a relaxed and open attitude toward the outside world. Because they dwell in regions that lack the towering peaks that their mountain kin favor, they build stone fortresses that start above ground and end in chambers that tunnel deep beneath the surface. A typical clan's settlement features stout walls and a sturdy gate, inside which are living quarters, community areas, and a well-protected treasure vault.

Hill dwarves are more perceptive and empathic than their kin. They rely on their intuition and insight to guide them in relationships with other races. To offset the disadvantage of not being protected by mountains, they frequently form defensive pacts with humans, gnomes, and elves that live nearby.

Although the best artisans are revered for their skills, just as in any dwarf clan, hill dwarves put special emphasis on diplomacy and trade as key elements in the clan's survival. They appreciate the value of creating high-quality goods to trade with others, both to enrich the clan and to form bonds with neighbors.

Mountain Dwarves. As tough and strong as the natural stoneworks they dwell among, mountain dwarves see themselves as the true progenitors of their race and the exemplars of their gods' traditions and teachings.

Mountain dwarves maintain a strong martial tradition. They know that the great wealth they accumulate in their vaults makes them prime targets for raiders. As a result, all the adults in a typical mountain dwarf clan are trained in the use of armor and weapons.

Miners are among the most revered members of a clan, since the tunnels and shafts they dig in search of ore are considered works of art in themselves—as much a part of a clan's legacy as any treasure chamber heaped with gold and gems.

The mountain dwarves' militancy and the need to protect their mines leads them into frequent clashes with Underdark monsters. Creatures or raiding parties that enter the mines from below invite retributive raids by dwarf war parties. The dwarves will mount an ambitious assault to reclaim even a single miner captured by attackers. Even the cruel drow are reluctant to raid mountain dwarf settlements, since they know a single attack will ignite the flames of war.

Hill dwarves view their mountain cousins as overly grim shut-ins who refuse to believe that life is anything but a constant battle for survival. Mountain dwarves view their hill-dwelling relatives as painfully naive optimists who risk losing their precious works because of their overexposure to the outside world.

Dwarves of the Forgotten Realms

In an age long since passed into myth, the dwarves of Toril were one people dwelling in the mountains where three continents—Faerûn, Kara-Tur, and Zakhara—met. A gradual diaspora over millennia spread them across the world, giving rise to diverse types of dwarves. In Faerûn, the two most numerous subraces are gold dwarves and shield dwarves.

The dwarves of Faerûn traveled north from the southern mountains and founded an extensive subterranean empire called Bhaerynden, which lay beneath a hot savannah now known as the Shaar. A rift in the leadership of the dwarves caused a schism among their people. One group left Bhaerynden and built new kingdoms in the North and the Heartlands, becoming the shield dwarves. Those who remained became the gold dwarves.

Gold dwarf scholars point to Abbathor as the cause of this division, claiming that the deity's influence weakened Bhaerynden and left it vulnerable to the dark elves that threatened its borders. That claim might well be true, but shield dwarf scholars point out that those who abandoned Bhaerynden did so two millennia before the drow conquered the place. They put the blame for its fall on the complacency that drove their ancestors to leave. "Gold dwarves endure. Shield dwarves adapt." That is a truism that both subraces of dwarves repeat with pride and derision, each extolling the qualities of their own kind.

Gold Dwarves. The conquest of Bhaerynden by the drow spurred its survivors to create many separate outposts in southern lands. During the same period, the dark elves fell victim to infighting, which culminated in the collapse of the great cavern. Emboldened by this development, armies of gold dwarves returned to drive the drow from the region. At the site that would come to be known as the Great Rift, they shaped the underground canyons and passages to their needs, and from there they tunneled under the Shaar for miles around, carving a new empire from stone.

Gold dwarves consider themselves the true keepers of dwarf culture. More so than shield dwarves, they prefer to dwell underground. Many gold dwarves live their lives without seeing the sun. Surrounded by the artistry and wealth that earlier generations have drawn from the earth, they are accustomed to flaunting their fortune, dressing in bejeweled and glittering garments. Gold dwarves who interact with other races (including shield

dwarves) tend to be suspicious, taciturn, and secretive, and especially distrustful of anyone who doesn't show outward signs of wealth.

Shield Dwarves. The ambition to seek new horizons that led the first dwarves to leave Bhaerynden still runs strong in shield dwarves today. Over thousands of years, many kingdoms of shield dwarves have risen, often at the whim of one enterprising individual who decided to found a new clan. So too have many kingdoms of shield dwarves fallen and been forgotten, leaving behind wondrous landmarks and mysterious dungeons.

Shield dwarves who occupy a stronghold can be as clannish and insular as gold dwarves, but shield dwarves are far more likely than gold dwarves to dwell in surface communities, forming trade relationships and alliances with neighboring nations. The openness of the shield dwarves as a people manifests on a personal level as well, with individuals being far more likely to travel among and make friends with other races.

Dwarves of Dragonlance

Most dwarves on the world of Krynn trace their ancestry to a single great empire known as Kal-Thax. They have long been split into several clans based on traditional roles that were established in Kal-Thax and its successor settlements. Yet, as with much on Krynn, the fate of the dwarves has been shaped by the Cataclysm.

Before the Cataclysm, the dwarves that dwelt on the surface, called the Neidar, interacted with other races and provided foodstuffs and goods for their subterranean cousins that couldn't be acquired underground. The great city of Thorbardin was the most prominent of the dwarves' underground settlements, where several clans lived and worked together.

But when the anger of the gods struck the world, mountains fell and seas rose. Although many settlements of dwarves were wiped out, Thorbardin survived. When the famine and plagues caused by the Cataclysm swept the world, the Neidar and their human allies sought succor from Thorbardin, which the Neidar knew held stores of food that could last generations. But the king wouldn't let any citizen of Thorbardin suffer to ease the anguish of the supplicants at its gates.

The result of that refusal was the Dwarfgate Wars, a series of sieges and battles that ended when a magical explosion and conflagration consumed both armies on the battlefield. Thorbardin's gates remained shut, and the hatred between the Neidar and the other clans has festered for centuries. Although some families among the Neidar eventually founded new communities, many of the surface dwellers drifted apart to take up life with humans or as lone traders and crafters.

Meanwhile, within Thorbardin, disagreements over the treatment of the Neidar, the loss of Thorbardin's army in the war, the distribution of supplies, and other disputes drove the clans farther apart. The Hylar are Thorbardin's best engineers and crafters, and that clan continues to rule despite its increasingly autocratic policies. Although the subservient clans continue to perform their traditional roles in the hierarchy, they have largely segregated themselves into separate districts within Thorbardin. The ambitious and vicious Theiwar clan maintains its influence through the use of mysterious magic. The Daergar grudgingly work as Thorbardin's miners when they aren't taking out their aggression on each other or antagonizing other clans. The Daewar long ago submitted to the rule of the Hylar and have the privilege of being Thorbardin's merchants and builders. Driven mad by their love of quicksilver, the wild Klar serve as Thorbardin's scouts and fiercest warriors.

Gully Dwarves. The Aghar clan is an anomaly among the dwarves of Krynn, having retained a foothold both in out-the-way locations inside Thorbardin and on the surface. Referred to by others as gully dwarves, the Aghar are derided as stupid, smelly, and dirty. Most dwarves consider them a form of vermin, unsuitable even as servants. The Aghar in Thorbardin have carved out living space for themselves from the massive piles of tailings left over from the excavations of the Daergar. They have no role in sustaining the city.

Dwarven Religion

Our forebears instill within us the potential for *everything that made them great. It is our responsibility to refine that gift into something wonderful.*

—Vistra Frostbeard

The religion of the dwarves is at the root of the societal roles that dwarves follow. Where most other creatures view their deities as ultrapowerful beings who stand forever apart from their worshipers, the dwarves see their gods as exemplars who blaze a path for their lives to follow. Dwarven deities exist in a wide variety, with a few common across many worlds. They are collectively known as the Mordinsamman.

Moradin is foremost among the dwarven pantheon, the epitome of everything dwarves strive to be. The rest of the group consists of those first dwarves who performed their labors so well that they could almost duplicate Moradin's level of skill.

The Dwarf Deities table lists the members of the Mordinsamman. For each god, the table notes alignment, province (the god's main areas of interest and responsibility), suggested domains for clerics who serve the god, and a common symbol of the god. Several of the gods in the table are described below.

Moradin

The father of the dwarves crafted his children from metal and gems and imbued them with souls as he cooled them with his breath.

Moradin is the master of every craft practiced by the dwarves and the patron of artisans. He expects his children to follow in his footsteps, studying his techniques and aspiring to one day match his expertise.

Priests of Moradin are responsible for judging and assessing the work of a stronghold's artisans. They keep great volumes that describe various crafting techniques in detail, and use the guidelines in them to judge the quality of individual works.

The priests also evaluate young dwarves to determine the youths' vocations. The decisions of the priests are accepted without question.

Dwarves like to blame the gods for their obsessions, whether craft, ale, or gold. There is a simpler explanation for the divine inspiration they claim to experience. Dwarves are neurotic.

Abbathor

The Great Master of Greed exerts an influence, no matter how subtle, over every dwarven heart. Abbathor teaches that greed isn't only desirable, but necessary to keep the dwarves in a strong and safe position.

Abbathor has no skill in crafting. Instead, he relies on his ability as a thief to take ownership of what he wants. Why work so hard to manufacture something when a much easier path to riches lies open?

Abbathor is the only advocate for change within the dwarven pantheon. He can inspire dwarves to seek shortcuts, normally frowned upon, but sometimes those methods turn out to be efficient techniques that improve a clan's capabilities.

Berronar Truesilver

The Matron of Home and Hearth is the patron of family, honor, and law. She lays out the rules for managing a dwarf clan.

Berronar's code establishes the laws of the dwarves, including contracts, trade agreements, and every other kind of bond forged through words and deeds. As Moradin provides the example that dwarves strive to match, Berronar provides the bonds that create dwarven society and culture.

Berronar's priests arrange marriages, using a process that finds the best matches and is designed to ensure that each generation of a clan is stronger and more talented than the last. Their dictates in this respect are sacrosanct, and a dwarf designated for an arranged marriage must obey the priests or risk exile.

Clangeddin Silverbeard

Known as the Father of Battle, Clangeddin Silverbeard is the patron of dwarf warriors. Impetuous and brave yet a cunning strategist, Clangeddin embodies the warrior's spirit that makes dwarven armies such formidable foes.

Clangeddin encourages dwarf warriors to venture out of the stronghold in search of foes to defeat. He particularly hates goblinoids, giants, and dragons. He compels his followers to seek out and dispatch such enemies before they can become a threat to the stronghold.

Clangeddin's faithful are mainly full-time warriors assigned to weapon training from an early age and expected to take the fight to the enemy. The two axes he wields embody his attitude, since he forsakes the added protection of a shield for the chance to deal more damage to his enemies.

Clangeddin's priests are warriors who lead from the front. When defending a stronghold, they guard the walls and lead sorties against enemy positions. When an external threat is near, the priests plan guerrilla raids to disrupt invaders before they can besiege the stronghold.

Dwarf Deities (The Mordinsamman)

Deity	Alignment	Province	Suggested Domains	Common Symbol
Abbathor	NE	Greed	Trickery	Jeweled dagger, point down
Berronar Truesilver	LG	Hearth, home, truth	Life, Light	Intertwined silver rings
Clangeddin Silverbeard	LG	War, strategy	War	Crossed silver battleaxes
Dugmaren Brightmantle	CG	Discovery	Knowledge	Open book
Dumathoin	N	Buried secrets	Grave,* Knowledge	Gemstone in a mountain
Gorm Gulthyn	LG	Vigilance	War	Bronze half-mask
Haela Brightaxe	CG	Combat prowess, luck in battle	War	Upright sword with blade sheathed in flame
Hanseath	CN	Festivity, brewing, song	Trickery, War	Beer stein
Marthammor Duin	NG	Explorers, wanderers, the lost	Nature, Trickery	Upright mace in front of a tall boot
Moradin	LG	Primary deity of dwarves	Forge,* Knowledge	Hammer and anvil
Muamman Duathal	NG	Storms, travel	Tempest	Mace held in gauntlets
Mya	NG	Clan, family, wisdom	Knowledge, Life	A faceless mother figure
Roknar	NE	Lies, intrigue	Trickery	Hands filled with coins
Sharindlar	CG	Healing, love	Life	Burning needle
Thard Harr	CG	Wilderness, hunting	Nature	Two clawed gauntlets
Tharmekhûl	N	Fire, forges, molten rock	Forge,* Light	Fiery axe
Thautam	N	Mysteries, darkness, lost treasures	Knowledge, Trickery	Blindfold
Ulaa	LG	Mining, quarrying	Forge*	A miner's pick
Valkauna	LN	Oaths, birth, aging, death	Grave,* Life	A silver ewer
Vergadain	N	Luck, wealth	Trickery	Gold coin bearing a dwarf's face

*Appears in *Xanathar's Guide to Everything*



Avatar of Moradin

Other Deities

The dwarven pantheon is quite large. The four deities discussed above are acknowledged by occupants of almost every stronghold, while the following gods are worshiped by some clans and ignored by others. These deities include Dugmaren Brightmantle, the Gleam in the Eye; Dumathoin, the Keeper of Secrets under the Mountain; Gorm Gulthyn, the Golden Guardian; Haela Brightaxe, the Lady of the Fray; Marthammor Duin, Watcher over Wanderers; Sharindlar, Lady of Mercy; and Vergadain, the Merchant King.

The Dual Role of Abbathor

A little act of selfishness now and then is to be *expected even from the wisest of folk.*

—Tenelar, Outcast of Five Peaks

Dwarves have rigid principles and lofty ambitions. They devote their lives to the pursuit of perfection, and the best come close to realizing that goal. But for all their dedication, dwarves are mortal, which means they are fallible. And that's where Abbathor comes in.

The dwarves' attachment to their creations has a dark side: many of them fall victim to feelings of selfishness and greed. The culprit is Abbathor, the black sheep of the dwarven pantheon. Abbathor is an advocate of change, not stability—an attitude normally regarded with suspicion by dwarves. But in this case, the god delivers his message inside the embrace of avarice.

Greed is at the heart of change. Greedy individuals aren't content with their own accomplishments and seek to undermine the works that others have made, sometimes going so far as to take credit for their creation, or actually steal them. Greed distorts the joy that dwarves normally take from their work. It focuses on the value of the end result, rather than the importance of the process of creation. A dwarf tempted by Abbathor might sabotage a rival's work or uncover a wondrous treasure and pass it off as something they created.

Abbathor does, however, play a positive role in helping the dwarves discover new methods and techniques. Although he espouses greed and treachery, he is also the standard bearer for revision and innovation. His guidance is especially critical when a clan faces an unanticipated situation that requires quick, decisive action.

In that vein, dwarf emissaries and merchants are expected to use Abbathor's tricks when they deal with humans, elves, and other races. When a dwarf offers a piece of merchandise for sale to an outsider, that merchant is expected to drive a hard bargain, even if the item is in truth an inferior example of its kind.

Fortunately for the other party in the arrangement, the dwarves' idea of "inferior" means that a product they consider substandard is still far superior to any such item that outsiders might create. The dwarves might laugh among themselves at a human farmer who bought a shovel from them that will last only a few decades. To the dwarves, that's a shoddy tool; to the farmer, it's a purchase that lasts a lifetime.

Enemies All Around

If the dwarves weren't so good at accumulating treasure, it's likely that they wouldn't have as many enemies. As things stand, however, almost every variety of

marauding humanoid or greedy monster lusts after the riches that dwarves keep in their strongholds. The biggest threats to their security are dragons and giants, but other humanoids such as orcs and the hated duergar are their most numerous foes.

In my experience—for all their long-winded rambling about lineage and tradition—dwarves are greedy and devious folk. I write this not to insult them in any way. I have found greed to be a useful motivator both for myself and my underlings, and I prize the trickery that some members of that race demonstrate.

Dragons

Chromatic dragons, by their nature, are often attracted to the treasures that dwarves gather in their fortresses. Although such a place might be too stout for a dragon to assault and take over, an evil dragon that makes its lair near a dwarven stronghold can be a threat to the occupants in many ways.

Black Dragons. Since black dragons prefer to dwell in swampland, one rarely makes a lair close to a stronghold. When a black dragon does cross paths with dwarves, it might attempt to isolate a settlement by making the roads leading to it impassable. The terrain around the dragon's lair is transformed into a riot of vegetation and patches of mud, slowing travelers and making caravans vulnerable to attack by the dragon's followers. When a stronghold becomes cut off, the dragon might start to test its outer defenses in advance of mounting a larger assault. This strategy can take years to come to fruition, but from the dragon's perspective it is time well spent.

Blue Dragons. Blue dragons are the least likely of their kind to tangle with dwarves, since their lairs are always far from where dwarves typically settle, and a blue dragon almost never gives away the location of its lair. One might appear before a band of dwarves traveling through the area and demand a toll for safe passage through its territory, expecting payment in the form of gems—and particularly sapphires.

Green Dragons. Dwarves and green dragons don't often interact, and when they do, the dragon doesn't usually threaten them directly. A typical green dragon has no burning desire to possess the material goods in a stronghold's hoard, and would much rather snatch up living treasure. Using its powers of deception, a green dragon might try to entice dwarves it encounters to ally with it in return for the promise of great wealth. Dwarves who have been touched by Abbathor might succumb to this temptation—only to find themselves imprisoned in the dragon's lair, sentenced to a lifetime of crafting new items for the dragon's treasure collection.

Red Dragons. Even though dwarves and red dragons compete for the same terrain, they don't come into conflict as often as they once did. Nowadays, red dragon lairs and dwarven strongholds are far enough apart that the dwarves don't have to worry constantly about being attacked. But occasionally, a young red dragon sets out to establish its own legacy—and what better place for a lair than one that comes with its own treasure hoard?

To begin its campaign, the dragon sends out followers and minions to lay siege to the stronghold. If this effort succeeds and the defenders withdraw deeper inside, the dragon comes forth to lead the assault into the tunnels. In those cramped quarters, only a few dwarves at a time can be brought to bear against the dragon's teeth, claws, and fiery breath. But the dwarves know that if they allow the dragon access to the fortress's innermost chambers, the fight is all but over.

White Dragons. Dwarves who live in cold climates don't usually have to cope with as many predators and marauders as do their kin in more hospitable terrain. But a white dragon patrols its territory relentlessly, neither subtle nor shrewd in its methods, often using natural camouflage to ambush its prey. A dragon that lairs nearby might be willing to leave a dwarven settlement unmolested if its appetite is sated by creatures it can catch in the open, including the travelers that enter and exit the place.

On occasion, this state of (relatively) peaceful coexistence is shattered when a devious rival dragon with designs on a white dragon's territory enters the picture. Taking advantage of the dragon's limited mental faculties, the rival secretly sends its minions out to harass the dragon. Convinced that the dwarves must be to blame, the dragon engages them in a wider conflict, and the dwarves respond in kind. Even if neither side destroys the other, both will be severely weakened, after which the rival moves in to finish the job.

Dwarves and Ale

Dwarves have a reputation for being able to consume great quantities of ale. Although drinking plays a significant role in their culture, it is a mistake to assume that intoxication has the same effect on them as it does on humans.

Humans drink to forget, while dwarves drink to remember. A dwarf deep in his cups is overcome by powerful, vivid memories of his past, especially events tied to lost kin, great deeds, or monumental failures.

When dwarves drink in a group, this effect spreads among them. The clan might joyfully sing of triumph as they reminisce over the defeat of a dragon, or weep as they recall the death of a beloved elder.

In contrast to clan gatherings, dwarves who drink alone invariably become morose and sullen—when separated from their clan mates, they can't avoid dwelling on unpleasant memories. It's the wise traveler who leaves alone the sole, drunken dwarf in the corner.

Giants

Giants have no special enmity toward dwarves, but they do consider them ideal slaves. Even when captured and put to work against their will, dwarves are innately driven to bring their full effort to a task at hand. Even simple toil brings dwarves some relief from captivity. Fire giants are more likely than other giants to enslave dwarves expressly for their talents. Many tribes of hill giants have discovered the value of dwarves as workers and now seek to capture them rather than devour them.

Giants don't launch direct attacks on dwarven strongholds except under extraordinary circumstances. Their size is a great disadvantage in the underground passages of a fortress, potentially turning any such assault into a suicide mission.

Orcs

Every orc tribe dreams of overrunning a dwarven stronghold and returning to the caves with a war wagon laden with gold, gems, stout armor, and sharp weapons. Given the orcs' propensity to rely on brute force rather than cunning, they can overcome only severely weakened dwarven strongholds. Unfortunately for the dwarves, orcs seem to receive omens from Gruumsh bidding them to invade a stronghold just when it is wracked with plague, riven by infighting, or otherwise at its weakest. The all-seeing eye of Gruumsh is ever vigilant for signs that Moradin's children have faltered.

Duergar

The evil dwarves of the Underdark are responsible for the constant undercurrent of peril in the life of any clan. Although the duergar don't come near the surface in sufficient numbers to invade and occupy a stronghold, they send out raiding parties to set upon any dwarves they find on the loose and to pull off occasional acts of sabotage or guerrilla activity. Though no dwarven fortresses are currently at risk of succumbing to a duergar onslaught, none of them are immune to the treachery that a small group of gray dwarves can commit.

When Clans Collapse

WE HAVE BUT ONE DESIRE—REVENGE AGAINST THOSE *who drove us out of our home.*

—Queen Helgret Deephammer,
of the Deephammer clan in exile

For all the attention dwarves pay to their defenses and the security of their homes, no clan is immortal and no stronghold unassailable. Threats to a clan can come from the outside or the inside, and it's often the latter variety that proves more difficult to defeat.

Every clan is aware that there are plenty of unprincipled creatures in the world that would love to steal its cherished works or even obliterate the dwarves and take over their home. Formidable though they may be, these are enemies that can be prepared for. More insidious are the forces that can tear apart a clan from within.

Festering Rivalries

It's not unusual for individuals in a clan to fall prey to occasional bickering and infighting. Abbathor's influence affects some dwarves more than others, and even those with the strongest resolve can be tempted to compromise their principles from time to time.

Minor turmoil of this sort rarely leads to civil war or a rapid decline of the clan's strength. But in the worst cases, a clan's collective lack of dedication to its goals strains the bonds between elements that must work together for the clan to prosper. Feuds between artisans drive wedges between families. Dwarf traders strike deals that fail to benefit the clan, and stone carvers start using short cuts that compromise their constructions.

If such a decline continues for too long and becomes too severe, the result could be a schism within the clan. The quarreling factions might segregate themselves in different parts of the stronghold; in an extreme case, some clan members might leave to found a new community. In either event, a divided clan is weaker than it was before the unrest occurred, and thus it's an easier target for outside enemies. If selfishness and greed were not enough to bring the clan to utter destruction, the horde of orcs waiting to attack will be happy to finish the job.

Friendly from a Distance

Even though dwarves have a natural affinity for one another, different clans keep a comfortable distance between their strongholds. Anyone not of the clan, even another dwarf, is considered an outsider.

Relations between neighboring clans are cordial, if not warm. They might exchange messengers to share lore and news that can prove useful against the vagaries of the outside world, but that is likely to be the extent of their contact. Under normal circumstances, dwarves prefer to be left alone. Interacting with neighbors brings unpredictability and change, things dwarves prefer to avoid.

Circumstances cease to be normal when a clan faces an external threat. When word gets out that one of their own is in danger, dwarves of other clans rally against the threat without question. The standoffish diplomacy that marks their normal relations gives way to an unshakable alliance. An attack on one dwarf clan is an attack against them all.

A Life in Exile

If the worst comes to pass and the loss of a clan's stronghold to invaders is inevitable, most of the dwarves would be willing to die while making a last stand for their home. But the clan must survive, even if only as a shell of its former self, and so every clan has a contingency plan to secure a safe escape for the stronghold's children and enough adults to care for them.

If the survivors are able to get away, they tend to seek shelter in a human city or kingdom. Their skill as artisans ensures that almost any community would welcome their contribution to the workforce, and they can eke out a comfortable existence for themselves.

A group of refugee dwarves seeking residence in a community will do whatever they can to live together, keeping the clan intact. They recreate what they can of their former lifestyle, living underground when possible and remaining isolated from their neighbors.

Dwarf Adventurers

THE MOUNTAINS WERE HOME ONCE, BUT NEVER AGAIN.

—Tenelar, Outcast of Five Peaks

A dwarf who leaves the stronghold to pursue a life of adventuring does so for one of two reasons. Some dwarves set out with the blessing of the clan to undertake an important mission. Others depart, willingly or otherwise, because they simply don't fit in.

When a situation calls for such drastic action, the nobles or priests select one or more clan members to venture forth. These dwarves are charged with a specific quest, such as recovering a stolen artifact or discovering

Clanless dwarves present an opportunity for wise employers and recruiters. They seek purpose and a firm footing. Give a clanless dwarf these things, and you will have a lifelong ally.

the fate of an allied stronghold that has fallen silent. They are held in high esteem by their clan mates, since they have dared to forsake the safety of home for the uncertainty of the upper world. When their mission is over, they return to the stronghold and are hailed as heroes.

Other dwarves turn to a life on the outside because they are misfits who found the stronghold stultifying or outcasts who were forced to leave the clan because of criminal behavior. Not all dwarves are born with the same strong sense of community, and the strictures of society can prove difficult for some to accept. Such an individual might protest an arranged marriage or insist that the priests of Moradin have erred in deciding their vocation. The rest of the clan views these malcontents with mistrust, and those who remain disruptive can find themselves exiled.

Hazardous Duty

Some dwarves leave the stronghold to serve the clan in nontraditional ways as envoys, explorers, crafters, and merchants. Although a human wouldn't think of all these folk as adventurers, in the dwarves' view they are undertaking a dangerous mission.

Even when dwarves volunteer for a life in the outside world, whether to take up true adventuring or to pursue a mundane occupation, they remain members of the clan, and their duties almost always include some responsibility to the clan. A blacksmith working in a human village, for instance, might report news of the outside world back to the clan.

Dwarves who reside in surface communities prefer to keep to themselves when not plying their trades, but over time they might develop close relationships with neighbors of other races—much in the same way that dwarves who join an adventuring party learn to trust their companions.

Castoffs and Criminals

Of course, not every dwarf is destined for a long life in service to the clan. A few are born with a tendency to think and behave in ways that undermine the clan rather than supporting it, and those who don't change their ways are cast out.

Some of these independent dwarves, especially those who espouse the moral and ethical standards of their kin, end up becoming adventurers. Their companions and allies satisfy every dwarf's innate need to belong to a clan, and those folk become the beneficiaries of the dwarf's industriousness and loyalty.

For dwarves of evil temperament, the place of one's clan is liable to be taken by a group such as an assassins' guild or an outlaw gang. Those who understand their role in the organization and abide by its hierarchy are some of the most loyal followers a would-be conqueror could acquire.

Magic: Gods' Gift to Dwarves

Dwarves are of two minds on the topic of magic.

They view divine magic as a gift from their gods, a direct helping hand meant to aid them in their effort to follow their gods' examples. Indeed, many forms of divine magic are essential for the smooth operation of any stronghold and the continued survival of the clan. For that reason, clerics are more common among the dwarves than in other races. Dwarves who are especially devoted to the clan are believed to have a special connection to the deities, and often learn how to use that conduit to bring forth divine magic.

Arcane magic in all its forms is a different matter. Dwarves have no innate fear or hatred of such things, but arcane magic has no true patron among the dwarven deities. As such, the dwarves ignore it in their daily lives, and clan members who take up the practice are exceedingly rare. Using arcane magic to assist in the creation of one's works is anathema to almost all dwarves, because the act amounts to nothing more than cheating. The few dwarves who embrace arcane magic tend to venerate Abbathor, if only in secret.

Evil dwarves with no respect for authority or community are few and far between. Shunned by the rest of their race, they take perverse delight in raiding villages, enslaving or killing innocents, and otherwise venting their rage against the world.

Duergar

Duergar see themselves as the true manifestation of dwarven ideals, clever enough not to be taken in by the treacherous deceptions of Moradin and his false promises. Their period of enslavement and the revolt against the mind flayers led by their god, Laduguer, purged the influence of the other dwarven gods from their souls and thus made them into the superior race.

Duergar have no appreciation for beauty, that ability having been erased from their minds by the mind flayers long ago and any thought of recapturing it obliterated by Moradin's betrayal. The duergar lead bleak, grim lives devoid of happiness or satisfaction, but they see that as their defining strength—the root of duergar pride, as it were—rather than a drawback to be corrected.

A Dark Reflection

Work or die. In the first case, you are useful. In *the second, you are entertaining.*

—Vozala Spikefist

Duergar society is a dark mirror of the dwarven clan. Where dwarves toil for love of industry, duergar do so out of a drive to create and own as much goods and treasure as possible. Their priests assign vocations and arrange marriages, but only to ensure that a clan continues to exist, not out of any sense of creating a legacy.

In many ways, the culture of the duergar is fundamentally hollow. For all their wars, and all the treasures they have accumulated, duergar feel no happiness or satisfaction. They simply continue to exist, ever-turning cogs in an engine of destruction that is the antithesis of the dwarves' joyful cycle of creation.



Laduguer Claims His Due

Our three rules come from the actions of Laduguer himself, as he quested through the Nine Hells on his mission to bring glory to the duergar.

First, the devils sought to turn his greed against him. They offered as much treasure as he could carry, thinking that he would take too much and collapse in exhaustion. Instead, Laduguer used his cunning magic to twist his pockets into bottomless pits, so that there was no limit to the treasure he could carry.

Then, in their frustration at his stratagem, the devils fell upon him with claw and blade. They didn't understand that with each treasure he claimed, Laduguer's will to win grew stronger and stronger. With so much to fight for, he lashed out and broke the backs of Hell's legions.

Finally, Asmodeus confronted Laduguer. The Lord of the Nine laughed, joked, and cajoled with all his guile, but Laduguer remained grim and stoic, refusing to be affected even when the mightiest celestials might have admitted some grudging amusement at the devil's antics. Laduguer was resolute because he wanted one final treasure: the allegiance of Hell in the coming war against the mind flayers. Asmodeus offered a world's worth of other temptations, but Laduguer's countenance never changed. Even when Asmodeus relented at last, Laduguer accepted the arrangement as nothing less than his due and refused to display any reaction.

Thus did Laduguer deliver the three rules that govern our people. These principles liberated our people from the illithids, and to this day they keep us strong.

—Felstak Goldgrief, Tyrant of Goethelskar

Three Rules of Conduct

Duergar psychology, culture, and society are predicated on three principles set down by their god Laduguer. Adherence to these precepts is now enforced by Laduguer's chief lieutenant, Deep Duerra.

Our Pockets Are Never Full

The duergar are fueled in all their actions by two pervasive feelings: ambition that never flags and greed that can never be satisfied. Though they might scheme and plot at great lengths to gain treasure or prestige, success is never a cause for celebration. Each acquisition, once in hand, is like a meal that quickly loses its appeal, leaving the duergar hungry for more. No matter how much wealth or power they gain, it's never enough.

Our Fight Is Never Done

As duergar acquire treasure and prestige, they need to become ever mightier to hold on to what they have. When the duergar wage war on other races, they demonstrate that the weak aren't fit to possess that which is meant for the strong. And to the duergar, no creatures are more unworthy of holding wealth than dwarves. When duergar have an opportunity to strike at dwarves, especially in their strongholds, they fight with utmost viciousness and cunning, matching the value of the spoils to be gained with the intensity of their onslaught.

Our Resolve Is Never Shaken

Any show of weakness is a mortal sin among the duergar, and that stricture extends to personal conduct as well as to the workings of a duergar clan. Displays

of happiness, contentedness, and trust are forbidden. The duergar are bound together in a rigid society, but it is a marriage of necessity rather than choice. In the Underdark, they must cooperate to survive. Within their society, each individual fills a role assigned to them and must perform it to the best of their abilities.

Duergar warriors epitomize the race's abandonment of emotion and individuality. In battle, they wear heavy armor and hateful, scowling masks that hide their identities. When assembled in ranks, the duergar move forward like army ants. They are an implacable, relentless foe, marching over the corpses of their fallen comrades to press the attack.

The mental power that duergar wield was given to them by the illithids, no matter what the adherents of Deep Duerra might claim. Why, then, would the illithids create slaves that could turn invisible or grow to ogre size? Most likely because those slaves would excel at herding their masters' other chattel. In retrospect, it seems arguable that the duergar escaped bondage because their jailers had already given them the keys.

Duergar Deities

Our gods sprang from among us. They endured *our hardships and carved a path to our salvation. What has your god done for you?*

—Morkai Ashlord

Two mythic figures who were long ago responsible for the duergar's liberation have achieved divinity in the eyes of their supplicants.

The Duergar Deities table provides basic information about each one: alignment, province (the god's main areas of interest and responsibility), suggested domains for clerics who serve the god, and a common symbol of the god.

Deep Duerra

According to legend, Deep Duerra stole the power of psionics from the mind flayers and gifted it to her people. Her command of it was so great that she dominated a mind flayer colony and turned the illithids into her slaves.

Deep Duerra's followers stand at the forefront of the duergar's attacks on their most hated enemies. Inspired by her mythic deeds, her priests are especially eager to find and annihilate dwarf communities and mind flayer colonies.

The priests of Deep Duerra maintain a training ground and armory inside each duergar stronghold. All duergar are required to learn the basic skills of combat, and the nobles are obliged to contribute weapons, armor, and followers to the stronghold's defensive force. The priests honor their deity by planning, equipping, and launching holy crusades against their enemies.

Laduguer

Also known as the Grim One, Laduguer was a mighty duergar warrior who liberated his people from the illithids. Laduguer entered into a pact with Asmodeus, pledging the duergar to an alliance against Lolth and the demons of the Abyss in exchange for which Laduguer received a spark of divinity from Abbathor himself.

Laduguer's teachings stand in direct opposition to everything Moradin represents. He is the dwarf god's dark opposite, a shadow that seeks to rise up and consume its original creator.

Duergar don't worship Laduguer in any traditional way; their communities include no temples or formal services. They honor their deity by acquiring more power and wealth through any means possible. Priests of Laduguer maintain the internal functions of duergar society but have no role that is expressly religious.

Inside a Stronghold

Duergar strongholds are best defined in terms of how they compare to the underground fortresses of the dwarves. Both places constantly bustle with activity, forges and picks and hammers always at work, but that's where the similarity ends.

In a dwarven stronghold, the atmosphere is one of optimistic industry. Dwarves enjoy what they do, and their dedication to furthering the clan and leaving a proper legacy shows through in every aspect of a clan's operation.

In contrast, the duergar care nothing for the dwarven ideal of achieving utmost mastery of a craft. For this reason, they pay no mind to their environment or the aesthetics of their creations. In a duergar stronghold, the atmosphere is one of unrelenting drudgery. Quantity, not quality, is at the heart of their efforts, as the duergar strive to craft as many items as possible in the shortest period of time. Duergar goods aren't flawed or substandard, but are plain to the point of austerity. To the duergar, a manufactured object is useful only for the function it performs.

In a typical stronghold, the workshops occupy the central chamber. The smoke that belches from them fills the air and drifts into surrounding passages.

Duergar Deities

Deity	Alignment	Province	Suggested Domains	Common Symbol
Deep Duerra	LE	Conquest, psionics	Knowledge, War	Mind flayer skull
Laduguer	LE	Labor, slavery	Death, Forge*	Broken arrow

*Appears in *Xanathar's Guide to Everything*



The outer edges of the stronghold are honeycombed with mining operations. The duergar wrest rock from the cavern walls and process the chunks in search of useful ore, pulverizing them with powerful mechanical devices and sorting out the metals, minerals, and gems.

Between the mines and the workshops stands a ring of fortresses, each ruled by a noble and occupied by the noble's followers. The stronghold's king commands the largest edifice, five times the size of the next biggest.

The priests of Deep Duerra reside in the second largest fortress, which houses the duergar army. The priests organize patrols and guard duty and oversee the settlement's armory.

Steeders, spiders that are used as mounts and war beasts by the duergar, are housed in stables that stand between the workshops and the fortresses. Each enclosure is virtually an individual prison, since the violent creatures must be kept apart lest they tear into each other or wreak havoc in some other way. Only careful supervision and brutal discipline keep them in line when they are out of their cages. Each noble is responsible for maintaining a set of steeder pens, and a squad of duergar are assigned to train and supervise the beasts.

Power of the Mind

THE MIND IS BUT ANOTHER MATERIAL, SET BEFORE US TO *shape into a weapon.*

—Gargosa Ironmind

During their period of slavery under the mind flayers, the duergar were the subjects of a variety of bizarre experiments that endowed them with psionic abilities.

Every duergar is born with some amount of psionic talent. The typical warrior can turn invisible or increase in size, and some duergar take up a more formal study of psionics to enhance or augment their capabilities. These individuals push their abilities beyond the normal limits, using what they learn to create new talents that they can then teach to others.

Despite these efforts, duergar still have a limited understanding of the true extent of their psionic capabilities. From the perspective of most other creatures, such abilities are seen as merely another flavor of magic. After all, they reason, what does it matter if a duergar turns invisible by using magic or a psionic ability? The outcome is the same either way.

Those duergar who delve into psionic research describe the process as accessing a dimensional space in which they can tap into the energy exerted by living minds. Using this power source, a small number of duergar can alter their bodies and those of other creatures, tap into thoughts and bend them as they see fit, and impart a spark of locomotion and even basic intelligence into objects. Duergar of truly exceptional skill can move

Duergar and Ale

Unlike their dwarven kin, duergar drink alcohol only in moderation and avoid overindulgence. The duergar have learned from bitter experience that those who drink too much risk awakening deep racial memories of their ancestors' cruel treatment at the hands of the mind flayers. The psychic agony that these memories evoke manifests in a severe flight-or-fight response. An intoxicated duergar might flee in panic and search for a safe place to hide until the effect wears off. A different one might respond by brawling with anyone in the vicinity, venting the rage the duergar harbor against their former masters.

Consider that the duergar began as homeless outcasts, and today their fortresses are some of the most impregnable strong points in the Underdark. The question might not be if they will conquer the realm below, but when.

objects without touching them, view creatures from a great distance, and push their bodies to achieve incredible feats, such as lifting a boulder or transforming into liquid to flow through a crack in a wall.

Building Better Slaves

For generations, duergar relied on humanoid captives to perform unskilled labor in their workshops. Only the lowest, most miserable duergar would consent to do grunt work that requires no artifice or skill.

In recent decades, however, the duergar have begun to move away from the practice of slavery. Some of them have discovered that mechanical servitors powered by psionic energy are more durable and more efficient than slaves. Thus, various kinds of automatons have been developed, each designed to fill a role within a duergar stronghold. Some clans have created models to make raiding parties more formidable. Other forms include digging and tunneling machines, golem-like monstrosities that tear through rock and extract ore from it.

Duergar Characters

Those duergar who become adventurers are almost invariably exiles from their society. The duergar have no patience for those who fail to conduct themselves with an appropriate amount of ambition and cruelty.

Any gray dwarves who leave the Underdark and take up adventuring, after having been raised among their own kind, are paranoid about possible treachery from within the party. One might insist on sleeping separately from the rest of the group, never displaying or sharing treasure, and trying to hoard treasures that can help survival, such as potions and items or spells that can allow the user to teleport to safety.

At the DM's discretion, you can play a duergar character. When you choose the subrace of your dwarf, you can choose duergar, using the following rules to create your character.

A Psionic Awakening

I performed the ritual just as the book described. As the magic turned the aboleth's brain to dust, I inhaled deeply of the leavings, and a nearly infinite roll of years began to unspool before my eyes.

I saw a red sun hanging in the sky over a desolate land, where the ruins of a castle slowly sank into a sea of dust.

I saw an alien empire in a formless, silver realm vanish in the wink of an eye, its slaves left to fend for themselves.

I felt the pull of a force more ancient than the gods, one that remained beneath the surface of my consciousness but was ready to receive a new disciple.

Since the day of my awakening I have felt a presence in the back of my mind, something that pushes to be set free as I struggle to stifle it. It grows, even as my ability to keep it inside falters. Will there come a day when my mind is no longer my own?

Final journal entry of Garral Longseer, once of Candlekeep, whereabouts now unknown

Duergar Traits

Duergar have the dwarf traits in the *Player's Handbook*, plus the traits below.

Ability Score Increase. Your Strength score increases by 1.

Superior Darkvision. Your darkvision has a radius of 120 feet.

Extra Language. You can speak, read, and write Undercommon.

Duergar Resilience. You have advantage on saving throws against illusions and against being charmed or paralyzed.

Duergar Magic. When you reach 3rd level, you can cast the *enlarge/reduce* spell on yourself once with this trait, using only the spell's enlarge option. When you reach 5th level, you can cast the *invisibility* spell on yourself once with this trait. You don't need material components for either spell, and you can't cast them while you're in direct sunlight, although sunlight has no effect on them once cast. You regain the ability to cast these spells with this trait when you finish a long rest. Intelligence is your spellcasting ability for these spells.

Sunlight Sensitivity. You have disadvantage on attack rolls and on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight when you, the target of your attack, or whatever you are trying to perceive is in direct sunlight.

Dwarf Tables

This section provides a number of tables useful for players and DMs who want to choose or randomly generate details about dwarf characters or settlements.

In the tables, a name in bold refers to a stat block in the *Monster Manual*.

Dwarves on the Move

When dwarves journey away from their strongholds, they prefer to move in substantial, heavily defended groups. Use the following tables to generate a band of dwarf travelers and some additional details of their situation. Roll once on each line of the Group Composition table and once on each table that follows it.

Group Composition

Members	Number Present
Dwarf **guards**	2d4 + 10
Dwarf **scouts**	1d8 + 2
Dwarf **veterans**	1d6 + 1

Group Leader

d6	Leader
1	Dwarf **priest**
2–4	Dwarf **noble**
5–6	Dwarf **knight**



Balthran Ireheart

Special Allies

d8	Ally
1–4	1d4 dwarf **acolytes**
5	1d3 **earth elementals**
6	1d4 trained **griffons**
7	1d4 **azers**
8	1 dwarf **mage**

Purpose of Travel

d6	Purpose
1	Merchant caravan
2	Seeking a specific enemy
3	Patrolling to keep roads safe
4	Delivering ransom for captive clan member
5	Fleeing attack on stronghold
6	Diplomatic mission

Special Circumstances

d4	Circumstance
1	Suspicious of all outsiders
2	Carrying secret message
3	Pursued by foe
4	Returning home laden with treasure

Dwarves in the Clan

The following tables can be used to create basic information about a clan of dwarves: the group's current status, a trait or a fact that sets that clan apart from others, and the vocation of a given clan member.

Clan's Status

d6	Status
1	**Prosperous.** Clan occupies original stronghold, currently flourishing
2	**Growing.** Stronghold expanding; glory days lie ahead
3	**Declining.** Clan population stagnant or decreasing
4	**Beleaguered.** Victimized by goblinoid and dragon attacks, intact but severely weakened
5	**Scattered.** Stronghold recently lost, many folk slain, survivors scattered
6	**Refugees.** Stronghold lost, survivors occupy a neighborhood or ward in human city

Clan's Notable Trait

d10	Trait
1	Founder was one of the greatest artisans in history
2	Clan owns a powerful artifact, such as an *Axe of the Dwarvish Lords*
3	Clan noted for expertise in a specific craft, such as brewing or armorsmithing
4	Clan has a sinister reputation, history plagued by scandal and mark of Abbathor
5	Militaristic clan, known for excellent fighting skills
6	Unusual stronghold, such as an undersea castle, a former cloud giant fortress, or an aboveground city
7	Prophecies indicate clan is destined to play a pivotal role in history
8	Heretical clan has rejected dwarf teachings in favor of human deities
9	Unique marker or curse, such as all clan members are hairless
10	Clan is known for its evil ways or a particularly sinister, notable member

Clan Vocations

d20	Vocation	d20	Vocation
1	Armorer	11	Merchant
2	Blacksmith	12	Messenger
3	Brewer	13	Miner
4	Carpenter	14	Potter
5	Cook	15	Scout
6	Envoy	16	Sculptor
7	Farmer	17	Shepherd
8	Hunter	18	Warrior
9	Jeweler	19	Weaponsmith
10	Mason	20	Weaver

Dwarves in the World

The tables below are designed to add depth to a dwarf character by offering possible reasons why the character left the clan for the life of an adventurer and a set of personality quirks tailored for dwarven sensibilities.

Dwarf Adventurer Story Hooks

d6	Hook
1	You were accused of stealing a fellow artisan's item and claiming it as your work. Innocent or guilty, you were made an outcast.
2	Your wanderlust prompted you to shirk your duties as a crafter in favor of wandering the world. Your clan isn't pleased with this choice.
3	You became separated from your clan due to an earthquake, a drow slave raid, or similar event and hope to return home.
4	You were assigned to become a merchant by the priests of Moradin and have yet to forgive them for their mistake. You should be working a forge, not wandering the outside world!
5	You are a spy, traveling incognito to gather information for the clan elders.
6	You struggle to resist the lure of Abbathor, but can't hold it at bay. Better to walk the world and sate your greed on non-dwarves.

Dwarf Quirks

d8	Quirk
1	Water from the sky! It always surprises you.
2	You have a fascination with the ocean and its chaos.
3	Any creature larger than a human makes you nervous.
4	You prefer to travel with a parasol or similar item that puts a comforting shelter over your head.
5	You prefer to sleep during the day.
6	You speak Common or any other non-dwarf language only if you must.
7	For you, relaxation is putting in a day at the forge.
8	You avoid contact with other dwarves, since you mistrust those who would leave their strongholds.

Duergar Tables

Most of the tables in this section are duergar-themed versions of the information for dwarves that's presented above and in the *Player's Handbook*.

In the tables, a name in bold refers to a stat block in the *Monster Manual*.

Duergar Raiding Parties

When duergar emerge from the Underdark, they generally do so in the form of small but vicious raiding parties. Use the following tables to generate a band of duergar raiders and some additional details of their situation. Roll once on each line of the Group Composition table and once on each table that follows it.



Group Composition

Members	Number Present
Duergar	2d6 + 5
Duergar stone guards	1d4 + 1
Duergar kavalrachni	1d4
Steeders, male	1d4

Group Leader

d6	Leader
1	Duergar stone guard
2–4	Duergar warlord
5–6	Duergar despot

Special Allies

d20	Ally
1–3	1d4 steeders, female
4–6	1d3 duergar hammerers
7	1 duergar mind master
8	1d3 duergar screamers
9–10	1d3 duergar soulblades
11	1d6 duergar xarrorn
12	1d6 **bearded devils** bound to service
13	2d4 allied evil **azers**
14	3d20 enslaved **goblins**
15	1d4 summoned **earth elementals**
16	1d6 + 2 **gargoyles**
17	1d8 **hell hounds**
18	1 trained **rust monster**
19	1 **shield guardian** bound to group leader
20	1d4 enslaved **trolls**

Purpose of Raid

d6	Purpose
1–3	Collecting slaves
4	Pursuing a specific enemy
5	Patrolling for expansion opportunities
6	On a rampage for loot

Special Circumstances

d4	Circumstance
1	Special hatred for dwarves, will attack them first
2	Exiles, willing to bargain
3	Laden with loot from raid, tries to flee
4	Seeks to take hostages for ransom

Duergar in the Clan

The following tables can be used to create basic information about a clan of duergar somewhere in the world: the group's current status, and a trait or a fact that sets that clan apart from others.

Duergar Clan Names

d12	Name	d12	Name
1	Ashlord	7	Mindeater
2	Battlegore	8	Necksnapper
3	Doomfist	9	Orehammer
4	Earthlord	10	Runehammer
5	Firetamer	11	Thundermaster
6	Knifemind	12	Underearth

Clan's Status

d6	Status
1	**Mighty.** Conquered several dwarven strongholds, dominates Underdark region
2	**Growing.** Stronghold expanding; glory days lie ahead
3	**Declining.** Clan growing stale, population falling
4	**Beleaguered.** Surrounded by drow and illithid foes
5	**Scattered.** Torn apart by slave rebellion or civil war
6	**Refugees.** Defeated by enemies, few survivors

Clan's Notable Trait

d12	Trait
1	Stole a mighty dwarven artifact
2	Has bound many devils to service
3	Experts in building mechanical devices
4	Conducts trade with the City of Brass
5	Notable for defeating many dwarves
6	Conquered and occupied a drow enclave
7	Is secretly controlled by mind flayers
8	Has enslaved a colony of troglodytes
9	Have interbred with devils
10	Known for its extensive spy network on surface
11	Masters of psionics
12	Dominated by a coven of warlocks



Duergar in the World

The tables below are designed to add depth to a duergar character by offering possible reasons why the character left the clan for the life of an adventurer and a choice of personality quirks that are tailored for duergar.

Duergar Adventurer Story Hooks

d6	Hook
1	You are a heretic, drawn to worship of Moradin.
2	Caught stealing, you escaped imprisonment but not before torture left you with a scar or lasting injury.
3	You were enslaved by drow or mind flayers but escaped to the surface.
4	You seek only to test yourself in battle with monsters.
5	Profit is all that matters to you.
6	The best way to defeat the folk of the surface is to study them firsthand.

Duergar Quirks

d6	Quirk
1	A separate personality in your mind provides advice and guidance to you.
2	Your gear must be perfectly arranged, otherwise someone must bleed.
3	When there isn't a roof over your head, you keep your eyes on the ground.
4	You don't talk unless you absolutely must.
5	The outside world is a giant cave, and nothing will convince you otherwise.
6	Humans fascinate you, and you collect odd trinkets of their culture.